

Users and employees have mixed reactions

As far as end-users of AI technology are concerned, there is high-level fear, uncertainty and doubt (FUD) amongst the majority. The sheer duality of this technology is a significant concern.

AI is a powerful tool, and just like any other tool, humans can use it for good or bad things. Moreover, since people are not yet actively talking about how to handle potential misuse of AI, this has remained as a growing concern.

Another reason for having a sceptical outlook towards AI is a plausible fear of job losses. If there are massive numbers of people losing jobs without an alternative system in place, it would be undoubtedly dangerous, and this can create chaos.

But then again, if you think about it deeply, you will realise that it is not losing a job that concerns many. What people usually worry about is having nothing better to do when their mainstream work is disrupted.

Unfortunately, majority of AI implementation projects do not address this issue upfront. Instead, it is done as an afterthought. It is perhaps the most substantial reason for being sceptical of AI.

At a superficial level, many of us appreciate the ease and convenience these AI solutions are providing.

However, our comfort erodes as these solutions start to increase their scope and touch critical areas of our life, such as banking, social benefits, security, healthcare, jobs, driving and others.

Bias and racism have been front-runners in the list of reasons for distrust in AI. People also fear that AI may show blatant disregard for human control. This, however, does not have any precedence, but it is practically possible and, hence, is a legitimate concern.

Errors-at-scale is not a widely-known issue, but those who have been victims of this problem in the past see it as one of the significant concerns when using AI in daily life. Imagine when a



Use of AI in dermatology (Credit: <https://www.airforcemedicine.af.mil>)

public AI system cancels credit cards of thousands of people because of some error. The scale of chaos this may cause is the main reason for this concern.

As a general observation, everyone is comfortable as long as applications are not touching or affecting core life matters. They are comfortable in areas of entertainment and luxury, but not so much when critical aspects of life are in the hands of an AI.

But enterprises have different views

Despite mixed feelings and heightened expectations from AI, the business world still has some ability to see AI in a relatively balanced manner. People from a wide range of industries agree that AI is tricky to deploy, and it could suck a lot of money and time before becoming useful. It can be costly, and initial payout can be quite modest (and sometimes lower than that). Overall payback period for any AI project has not been attractive, and in many cases, it is hard to establish the same objectively.

Several experts find it unsettling that some vendors are pushing AI systems even before they figure out the purpose and claim to know

what problems these will solve. Some businesses discourage this approach, and are taking a prudent view, but they are in a minority. Most companies blindly believe otherwise.

It is one thing to see breakthroughs in gaming AI, such as in the game of Go and Chess, or having devices that turn on music at voice command. It is another thing to use AI and make changes in businesses, especially ones that are not fundamentally digital.

When it comes to improving and changing how businesses get done, AI and other tools form only small cogs of a giant wheel. Changes that bring about company-wide repercussions are a different ballgame.

Change management has not been easy to handle in the past, and it is not going to be any different in the future either. Several experts from various business domains need to be involved for any significant change to occur, and they have to be the best if we are looking for effective outcomes. This essentially means pulling the best people from routine business work and letting them focus on AI implementation. This is a challenging proposition for businesses of any size.